▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

WATER AND IRE IN THE VALLEY

Having put a question mark over the Indus Waters Treaty, should India go ahead with stalled projects? The Indo-Pak debate flows into Kashmir's domestic politics

By **Kaleem Geelani**

project on one of Asia's largest lakes, Wular, in north Kashmir? India had called it a pure navigation facility when launching it in 1984. Pakistan claimed it had a storage facility of 0.3 million acre feet (MAF), not permitted under the IWT. Abandoned in 1987, even 12 rounds of secretary-level talks yielded no result. A terror attack at the site in 2012 threw yet another spanner in the works.

Omar wants it revived. "It will give us the advantage of using the Jhelum for navigation," he wrote on X, with a video showing half-developed structures encircled by a barrage. It would also boost "downstream power projects", he wrote. That initiated his first major faceoff with arch political rival Mehbooba Mufti in this stint. The PDP chief said his wish amounts to "weaponisation of waters" in an already fraught scenario. Appeasement of Pakistan, he said. Speak for your party, she said, imputing such inclinations to Omar's grandfather and National Conference founder Sheikh Abdullah.

J&K, meanwhile, is crippled by an energy crisis. Six major hydel plants on its soil, with an annual capacity of 2,250 MW, were earmarked for the national grid in 2000. The 13 plants given over for local consumption, including Baglihar, generate only 1,197 MW, against a peak demand of 2,800 MW. That forces heavy reliance on power purchases, costing the exchequer up to Rs 10,000 crore a year.

Takeaways

- **CM Omar Abdullah wants Tulbul navigation project, stalled since 1987, revived**
- **Mehbooba Mufti calls it "weaponisation of water" in a fraught post-war situation**
- **J&K's energy crisis and the damaging effects of climate change spark calls for a rational renegotiation of IWT**







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The IWT, signed in 1960, allows only run-of-the-river projects, with total storage of 1.6 MAF for power generation in western rivers. Pakistan has blocked everything else. Negotiations, for instance, failed to resolve the 850 MW Rattle project, even after a 40-member global panel of experts from the US, UK, Australia, Russia and Canada, along with Indian and Pakistani representatives, visited Kishtwar in 2024.

But circumstances have altered since 1960, with less snowfall and erratic precipitation patterns. "It's essential to address emerging challenges unforeseen in 1960, such as climate change impacts on the cryosphere, groundwater depletion, water pollution and their consequences, either through supplementary protocols or within the treaty," a professor and expert on climate change and glaciology at the University of Kashmir told INDIA TODAY.

Away from the spotlight, the Inland Waterways Authority of India set foot here on May 13, with an office in Srinagar and a purse of Rs 100 crore. Its work is kosher, since IWT allows "non-consumptive use". Will that be scaled up? The best way would be a rational renegotiation, within an ecologically integrated Indo-Pak framework. Much blood has already flowed down these waters. ■